

The Cosmic Horror Index

Rating Every Cosmology on the Lovecraft Scale

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Does the universe care about you?

Most traditions say no.

But *how much* they don't care — and *why* — varies dramatically.

The Cosmic Horror Index measures that variance
from textual evidence, not intuition.

The 10 Axes

Axis	High score	Wt
Indifference to humans	Universe doesn't notice us	2×
Incomprehensibility	Reality breaks minds	2×
Human insignificance	We are cosmically irrelevant	2×
Omniscience	All-knowing ultimate reality	1
Omnipotence	Absolute, unchallengeable power	1
Self-sufficiency	Needs nothing from creation	1
Cyclical destruction	Cosmos destroys and rebuilds	1
Awe / madness induction	Truth is unbearable	1
Creation without consent	Existence imposed on beings	1
Moral neutrality	Beyond good and evil	1

Shaded axes carry 2× weight — they are Lovecraft's signature.

The Formula

CHI score = weighted mean of 10 axis scores, each on $[0, 100]$:

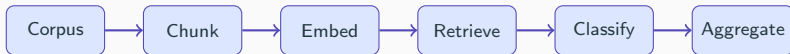
$$\text{CHI} = \frac{2 \cdot S_{\text{indiff}} + 2 \cdot S_{\text{incomp}} + 2 \cdot S_{\text{insignif}} + \sum_{7 \text{ others}} S_i}{13}$$

Each axis score from passage-level LLM classifications:

- Retrieve top-20 passages per (tradition, axis) via FAISS semantic search
- Claude scores each: *relevance* $\in [0, 1]$, *valence* $\in [-1, +1]$, *confidence* $\in [0, 1]$
- Axis score = $\bar{v}_{\text{weighted}} \times 50 + 50$, where weights = rel $\times$ conf
- 95% CI from 1000-iteration bootstrap

Every score is traceable to specific passages.

NLP Pipeline



Retrieval

Probe queries per axis
Dynamic overfetch
for small traditions

Classification

Structured JSON output
Relevance gates passage
min threshold = 0.2

Cost

\$9.40 full run
\$0.72 / tradition
~2 hr on CPU

Scale

13 cosmological traditions

14,096 text chunks

all public domain (pre-1928)

Sources

Project Gutenberg (primary)

AccessToInsight (Buddhism)

gnosis.org (Gnosticism)

sacred-texts.com

Traditions

Lovecraft • Absurdism • Daoism

Gnosticism • Pantheism • Norse

Bhakti Hinduism • Advaita Vedanta

Aztec • Shinto • Greek

Egyptian • Buddhism

Validation

Keyword check after every download

7 wrong PG IDs caught & corrected

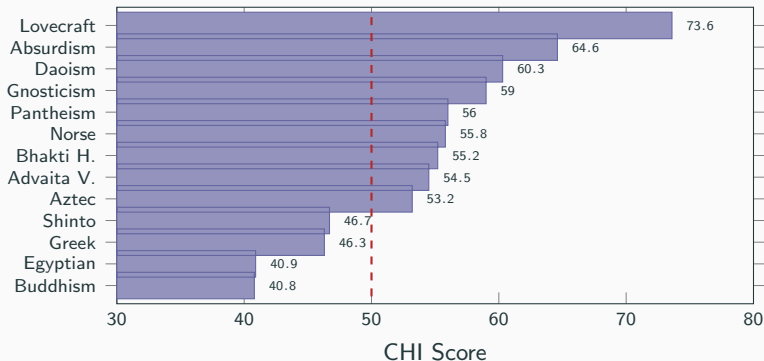
Results

#	Tradition	CHI
1	Lovecraft	73.6
2	Absurdism	64.6
3	Daoism	60.3
4	Gnosticism	59.0
5	Pantheism	56.0
6	Norse	55.8

#	Tradition	CHI
7	Bhakti Hinduism	55.2
8	Advaita Vedanta	54.5
9	Aztec	53.2
10	Shinto	46.7
11	Greek	46.3
12	Egyptian	40.9
13	Buddhism	40.8

Lovecraft is the calibration anchor. Buddhism is the low anchor.

Finding 1: Most Cosmologies Lean Cosmic Horror



10 of 13 traditions score above 50. The universe's indifference is a near-universal insight.

Finding 2: Three Phases of Cosmological Horror

Phase 1: Ancient

Egyptian, Greek, Buddhist

CHI: 41–46

Gods are *involved* —

they judge, reward,
and punish humans.

Humans matter.

Phase 2: Lovecraft

Norse, Daoism,

Gnosticism, Absurdism

CHI: 55–73

Indifference becomes
explicit. Cosmos is
vast and uncaring.

We never mattered.

Phase 3: New Weird

VanderMeer,

Ligotti, Watts

CHI: 80+ (*est.*)

Horror is the
default state.

Consciousness is
the aberration.

Not yet scored.

Open Dataset

Repo

`github.com/seckinozbek1/cosmic-horror-index`

What's included

`output/chi_dataset_grounded.json`

All 13 traditions, 10 axes, bootstrap CIs

`output/evidence_document.md`

Every score traced to specific passages

`config/pipeline_config.yaml`

Axes, probes, corpus sources

Interactive viz

`seckinozbek1.github.io/cosmic-horror-index/`

Adding a tradition

1. Find public domain text (PG)
2. Verify PG ID (never guess)
3. Add to `pipeline_config.yaml`
4. `python tasks.py corpus <name>`
5. `python tasks.py validate-corpus`
6. `python tasks.py embed`
7. `python tasks.py score <name>`

Cost: \$0.72 per tradition

See `docs/ADDING_A_TRADITION.md`